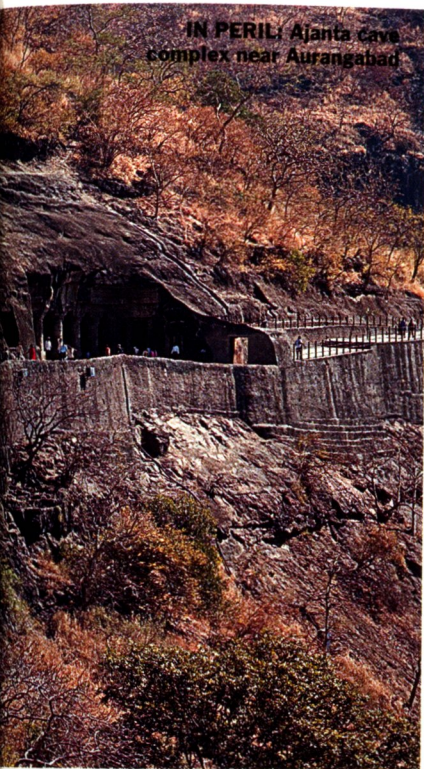


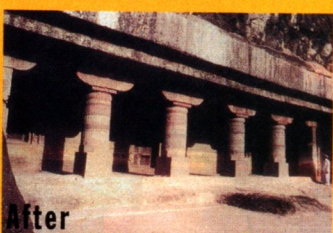
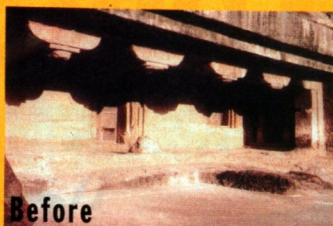
IN PERIL: Ajanta cave complex near Aurangabad



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ILL-ADVISED PRETTIFICATION

The ASI has rebuilt pillars in Cave 21. It is facing criticism from many quarters for using cement in restoration work.



THE PROBLEMS

ASI's plan to remove loose boulders as well as rebuild the portico in Cave 1 has sparked a fresh controversy.



The boulders are unstable and ASI planned to rebuild the portico in Cave 1

160-year history, has seen advances in both material research and philosophical approach. The contemporary approach the worldover is that a monument should be presented as authentically as possible.

But the bigger problem, says ASI, quoting data from GSI, is that 30 of the 90 loose boulders are in danger of falling. ASI Director General Anshu

Vaish says, "Already there have been rockfalls at night. But nobody was hurt. The most recent was in July last year," she says. Spink says he is shocked that a removal of boulders is being considered. "The chances of their falling are slight, since they have been balanced there for at least a million years." ASI has perhaps erred on the side of caution, trying to fill every

gaping joint and reconstruct every broken pillar but the immediate provocation for this controversy was the Cave 1 portico that ASI was repairing. According to Dev Mehta, convener of Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH), Maharashtra, similar structural work was stalled in October, outside Cave 1, which has the famous Padmapani and Vajrapani paintings, after objections.

Spink has compared this plan to the cement prosthesis which was added to the left side of Cave 19. As he writes, "Even if we disregard the soberingly unhappy life-expectancy of such cement additions, and even if scholars would recognise that the reconstruction is faulted from an architectural point of view (which it is), we are still left with the fact that, compared with the "original" right side, the cement additions do not "sing"; but tourists (and it was surely made for them not scholars, who don't want such fakery) will not feel this; they will only sense that King Upendra-gupta, who commissioned the cave, bought some of the stuff at Walmart." Vaish brushes the criticism aside, saying the plan to repair the portico was undertaken only after ASI collected all the previous photographs and drawings from the archives. She has a sort-of-clean chit from Francesco Bandarin, Director, World Heritage Centre, who has written that he is awaiting comment from a panel of experts.

The 29 Ajanta caves rise in a horseshoe shape above the Waghora river. Its 2,000-year-old murals are astounding in their detail and have had enormous impact on other nations, linked as they are inextricably with the history of Buddhism. Every single pillar, statue, elephant and Buddha remains a testament to Indian art, rediscovered on a tiger hunt only as late as 1819 by a Madras Army captain, John Smith. These caves were sponsored by wealthy merchants under the Satavahana dynasty, and then again in the 5th century by King Harisena of the Vakataka dynasty, who added 23 caves to the six already made by that time. While some were used as monasteries, others were halls of worship. The site gets about six lakh visitors every year. And has withstood the vagaries of nature so far. ■